



How we Test

It looks good and the technology is glitzy, but does it do the job?

The Digital Media Test & Research Centre (DMTRC) conducts a series of elaborate tests to evaluate the merit of each hardware and software product. To ensure that our readers have all the information they need to make an informed buying decision, engineers at DMTRC evaluate and review the latest hardware, software and technology services in accordance with the most up-to-date evaluation processes and methodologies used around the world.

Comparison Tests

We use a dual rating system, the first of which is applied to the Comparison Tests in which we compare the performance of products within a particular category.

Each product is evaluated under different parameters such as performance, value for money, features, warranty and support, etc.

Weightages are then applied to the various test parameters according to their importance for that particular category of products.

These weightages are then used to arrive at an overall grade for each individual product. An overall grade of A+, therefore, indicates that the product is close to perfection.



The Awards

Digit awards outstanding products by selecting a Best Performance and Best Value winner in each comparison test. The winner of the Best Performance Award will be the product that scored the highest in the performance segment of our tests.

This award represents the best performing product in our tests and doesn't factor in any other parameter such as value for money, features, support, etc. The winner of the Best Value Award will be the product that scores the highest in our value for money parameter which is derived



taking into account the ratio of a product's performance and features to its price. The product winning this award offers good performance at a great price.

In Bazaar

The second part of the rating system is used to evaluate individual hardware and software products in the Bazaar section. The evaluation covers parameters such as performance, ease of use, value for money and the build quality/features of the product in question and then arrives at an overall rating.

Here each of these parameters is given a weightage of 25 per cent and is rated on a scale of 5, which is represented by arrows (▶).

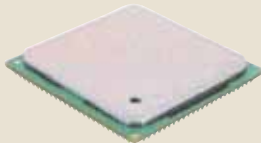
The greater the number of arrows, the better the product. This simple five-point rating system is designed to give you an easy-to-interpret assessment of a product. For example, a product that receives an overall score of five arrows signifies an outstanding buy!

In Test this Month

Our cover story this month presents you with a comprehensive analysis of the processors and the motherboards available in the Indian market. We have tested



a total of 48 motherboards and 16 processors, covering both the Intel and the AMD platforms. The test analysis will help you make the right decision whether you wish to buy a processor, a motherboard or are looking for a complete solution involving both these essential components.



Next up we have the Bazaar section bringing in a wealth of gadgets. Two products from Palm appear on the handheld radar—both the high-end and feature-rich Palm Tungsten T and the budget Palm Zire are duly analysed. We also test a 1GB IBM Microdrive and the brand new Creative SoundBlaster Audigy2 Platinum, which features a culmination of all of Creative's former technologies. Also tested are the Labtec Pulse 420, a 2.1 speaker set; the Logitech MX500 Optical Mouse and the ACI Ethos 4 Laptop. The software front is represented by RestoreIT! Deluxe, a backup and restore application; and WebCafe, a tool meant for managing cyber cafes.



The 5-point Rating System used in Bazaar	
▶▶▶▶▶	Excellent: a brilliant combination of price, performance and features—far beyond expectations
▶▶▶▶▶	Good: a good buy, better than most products in its category
▶▶▶▶▶	Average: reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product
▶▶▶▶▶	Mediocre: does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas
▶▶▶▶▶	Poor: has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application